

SEVEN CHURCHES THE CHURCH OF EPHEBUS

TEXT: Revelation 2:1-7 (NKJV) *“To the angel of the church of Ephesus write, These things says He who holds the seven stars in His right hand, who walks in the midst of the seven golden lampstands:2 “I know your works, your labor, your patience, and that you cannot bear those who are evil. And you have tested those who say they are apostles and are not, and have found them liars;3 “and you have persevered and have patience, and have labored for My name’s sake and have not become weary.4 “Nevertheless I have this against you, that you have left your first love.5 “Remember therefore from where you have fallen; repent and do the first works, or else I will come to you quickly and remove your lampstand from its place—unless you repent.6 “But this you have, that you hate the deeds of the Nicolaitans, which I also hate.7 “He who has an ear, let him hear what the Spirit says to the churches. To him who overcomes I will give to eat from the tree of life, which is in the midst of the Paradise of God.”*

INTRO: If you had been living at the time of the writing about the seven churches of Revelation and you wanted to live in the most exciting city in the world, you probably would have selected Ephesus. Two hundred thirty cities dotted the coastline of Asia Minor, and many of them were great cities, but Ephesus was the crown jewel of them all.

Ephesus was not only known for its commercial trade, but for the great Temple of Diana, which was one of the Seven Wonders of the World. Diana was the goddess with the grotesque head and many breasts which focused her worshiper’s attention on the sensual pleasure of prostitution.

Paul went to Ephesus on his third missionary journey. He stayed there two years. He wrote the following concerning this city. 1 Corinthians 16:9 (NKJV) *“For a great and effective door has opened to me, and there are many adversaries.”*

The church of Ephesus is the first church we read about in the book of Revelation. The seven churches are: Ephesus, Smyrna, Pergamos, Thyatira, Sardis, Philadelphia, and Laodicea. In addition to these there were other churches in Asia. Acts 20:5, Acts 20:17, 2 Corinthians 2:12, Colossians 1:2, Colossians 4:12.

The Bible does not tell us why John did not write to them, but we can assume two things:

- God chose the seven churches that were symbolic of seven kinds of churches that were to exist in the future.
- Even though each of the seven churches had similarities, each one was different. This is, and always has been, true.

There are many churches around us today but they all fall into a handful of categories.

Only as we do a sincere, honest, inventory of ourselves can we find which church we are and where we stand with the Lord Jesus Christ. Let us look at the seven verses of scripture that deal with the church at Ephesus to see how we, as a church, compare to that church. The first thing the Word of God reveals to us about the people in the church at Ephesus deals with.....

I. THE LEADER...

In verse 1 we read, **Revelation 2:1 (NKJV)** ***To the angel of the church of Ephesus write, These things says He who holds the seven stars in His right hand, who walks in the midst of the seven golden lampstands.*** Notice this letter is addressed to the leader of the church the word ***“angel”*** is singular, not plural. He is not addressing all seven church leaders; He is addressing the one leader of the church of Ephesus.

This letter is written to the ***“angel”*** or the pastor. The reason for this is the pastor is the messenger of God to the church.

God does not tell the deacons and have them to tell the pastor what He wants. God holds the pastor personally responsible. God is a God of organization, not a God of confusion. **The pastor must never forget that God has placed him over the flock and with that special responsibility come special accountability for the task assigned.** 1 Peter 5:2 (NKJV) ***“Shepherd the flock of God which is among you, serving as overseers, not by compulsion but willingly, not for dishonest gain but eagerly; (3) nor as being lords over those entrusted to you, but being examples to the flock.”***

The pastor is to:

- Shepherd the flock... Feed the flock!

- Take the oversight... Set the direction!
- Live an exemplary lifestyle... Set the values!

Notice some things that verse one tells us about the minister God. He is referred to as an “*angel*.” Then notice, John switches to the plural – “*stars*.” That is, God holds all of His ministers in His hands.

The minister of God is:

- Held in the hands of Christ...
- Hand-picked by Christ and placed in His hand...
- Nourished and nurtured by the hand of Christ...
- Protected by the hand of Christ...
- Positioned for a close relationship, being in the hand of Christ...

Why? The position of pastor is the leading position in the church. Every entity on earth must have a leader:

- A family needs a leader...
- A nation needs a leader...
- A business needs a leader...
- A team needs a leader...
- A church needs a leader...

When God was ready to address the church at Ephesus, He recognized the pastor as the leader of His church as a result it was to the pastor this letter was written.

II. THE LAMPSTAND...

Revelation 2:1 (NKJV) *“To the angel of the church of Ephesus write, “These things says He who holds the seven stars in His right hand, who walks in the midst of the seven golden lampstands:”* The seven golden lamp stands represent the seven churches of Revelation.

As a pastor, I cannot express how honored I feel to have you as a part of this church. I recognize there are good churches all over this city that you could attend, but you are here because God has led us together to build a lighthouse for Him in this community. As much as words can convey, I deeply appreciate every one of you! But not one of us would be here if the Lord Jesus was not here.

Sometimes we hear people say, *“I do not like to go to church.”* Generally they are not trying to be ugly when they say that; they sincerely mean it. They are not to be blamed. There are some churches Christians are not comfortable in. Why? If God is not there, they do not want to be there either.

What is a church? Simply defined, it is: *“A group of people who have been called out and redeemed for the purposes of God.”*

Look at verse 1 again, *“.....who walketh in the midst of the seven golden candlesticks.”* Look at that word *“midst.”* It is the same word we see in the promise in [Matthew 18:20](#). (KJV) *“For where two or three are gathered together in my name, there am I in the midst of them.”* The thing that separates the church from a social club is the presence of the Lord.

The streets of gold are not what will make heaven a great place. What is going to make heaven so great is the Lord Jesus. He is going to be the center of attraction! The thing that makes a church a great place is not the building the people worship in, but the Lord who meets them there! There would be no reason to assemble if He were not here. If He were not here we might as well attend the Rotary Club!

If a church has lost the presence of the Lord, it has lost everything. The people may as well shut the door and write *Icabod* (The glory of the Lord has departed) across the door. We should never take the presence of the Lord for granted but cherish it as a thing of value!

Similarly, what will make Hell so terrible are not the eternal flames, nor the evil people who will inhabit that place! The thing that makes hell so terrible is the fact that there will be eternal separation from the presence of the Lord!

John tells us about the leader and the lamp stand of the church of Ephesus. He also tells us about.....

III. THE LABOR...

[Revelation 2:2-3](#) (NKJV) *“I know your works, your labor, your patience, and that you cannot bear those who are evil. And you have tested those who say they are apostles and are not, and have found them liars;³ “and you have persevered and have patience, and have labored for My name’s sake and have not become weary.””*

Look at the word “**know**” in verse 2; it means the Lord has a clear vision of what was being done in the church of Ephesus! He was keeping record of their deeds! If He was doing this with them He is keeping record of our labor as well.

Nothing can obstruct His view of the church. He not only sees who is in attendance He also is able to look into the hearts of those who attend and knows why they attend His church. God always looks past the action to the motivation. He will reward motivation before He will reward participation! It is at this point that many people will lose their reward. (We need to get our want to fixed...)

The church of Ephesus was a busy church. The church calendar was filled with many things.

ILLUSTRATION: They were not like the church that sent their annual report into headquarters which stated, “*No converts, no baptisms, no new members by letter, no deaths, no births, no gifts to missions.*” Then, at the bottom of the report, a note was added which said, “*Brethren, pray for us that we will hold our own.*”

That was not the case with the church of Ephesus. Their people could write a wonderful report telling headquarters what they were doing. Look at what the Lord Jesus said about them “***I know your works and your labor...***”

We need to understand here the Lord is commending believers for their works. He does not ask lost people to work for Him. Why? Because if He did they would think they were earning their salvation by those good works. However, we who are saved by His marvelous grace are expected to work. If we are truly saved we will want to work!

If we are not willing to work then God’s work will not be done. It is not a situation where God cannot do His own work; He has chosen us to do His work so that we can learn responsibility and receive reward.

The church of Ephesus was not like many churches today. Often it is hard to find Christians willing to work for the Lord, but the Word of God tells us the Christians of Ephesus were willing and they labored for the Lord. (20% of the people do 80% of the work... 20% of the people finance 80% of the work)

“I know your patience...” In that pagan land, where the goddess Diana was supreme, the Christians encountered many problems, but God commended them because they were patient and did not quit on the work he had called them to do.

“I know how thou can not bear them which are evil...” Look at the phrase, ***“.....can not bear.”*** The Ephesians would not tolerate for a moment a church leader who did not live a holy life. In far too many cases this is a break from the norm in today’s church culture. [**The church of Ephesus would not tolerate immorality within the leadership structure of the church.**](#)

“I know you have tried them which say they are apostles, and are not, and have found them to be liars.” Notice the words ***“tried them.”*** This church was careful not to embrace every fad and new doctrine that made its way around the religious establishment. They literally checked people out with the Word of God and if they did not line up with God’s Word they dismissed them with their teachings. Is this a scriptural practice? Yes, it was – and is! [**I John 4:1\(KJV\) “Beloved, believe not every spirit, but try the spirits whether they are of God.....”**](#) God has warned us that ***“wolves”*** would come to us in ***“sheep’s”*** clothing, yet many today fall headlong into every new fad and doctrine that comes along!

“I know how you have borne, and have had patience, and for my name’s sake have labored, and have not fainted.” [**The church of Ephesus suffered many difficulties, but they stood for the name of Christ.**](#) Notice, under such a stressful load they did not faint. [**2 Thessalonians 3:13-14 \(NKJV\) “But as for you, brethren, do not grow weary in doing good.14 And if anyone does not obey our word in this epistle, note that person and do not keep company with him, that he may be ashamed.”**](#)

ILLUSTRATION: D.L. Moody came home from holding a meeting completely exhausted. His family begged him to stay home and rest before he went on to his next meeting. He told them ***“I grow weary in the work but not of the work.”***

You see, everyone who has ever faithfully served the Lord knows what he means. Sometimes our bodies are exhausted because of the load we are carrying, but we never think of giving up because of the load. We may grow

weary in the work of God, but God helps us to never grow weary of His work.

IV. THE LEAVING...

So far, [everything we read about this church seems to describe a good to great church](#). In fact, I do not know many pastors who would not be honored to pastor such a church. This church had a God called Pastor and leadership team; the Spirit of the lord is obviously present; each person is finding their place and working as hard as they can; this church should be a pleasure to pastor.

But remember, God, who said that He knew their works, labor, patience, etc. is the God who can look into the hearts of men and see what others cannot see! [There was a problem with this church which was not apparent to the casual observer](#). God looked into their hearts, after saying all those nice things about them, and exposed a major fault. Vs. 4 ***“Nevertheless I have somewhat against thee, because thou have left your first love.”***

Our love for the Lord is what makes His church an exciting place to be. It is possible to serve God every day of the week because it is routine instead of serving Him out of love for Him. [There is a distinct difference between loving God and working for Him](#). You can almost hear the hurt in the voice of the Father as he makes this indictment against this church. He is saying you are working hard enough but you have neglected the one who has redeemed and called you! This can be a problem for all of us, we mistake busyness for relationship and they are birds of a different feather.

V. THE LESSON...

[The lesson to be learned from the church of Ephesus is that we can go through all the ritualism of worship and service and still find ourselves coming up short on our love relationship with the Father](#). He is a jealous God!

Instead of church being a place where Christians meet because they love the Lord, it can become a place where we report for a work detail.

It is possible to:

Place God's tithes and our offerings in the offering receptacle and never consider God in our thoughts...

Sing beautiful songs and never think about the words we are singing...

Hear wonderful sermons from the Word of God and never allow them to penetrate our hearts...

Jesus said to the church of Ephesus, and other churches that are like them, ***“Remember therefore from whence thou art fallen, and repent and do the first works; or else I will come unto thee quickly, and I will remove thy candlestick out of his place, except thou repent.”***

We are being commanded to work on our relationship with the Father and restore what we had when we first came to know Him. We are to allow clean hearts to return; the joyous service; the determination to tell everyone the good news; the outright devotion to His cause; and our desire to please Him above all else.

If this does not happen the presence of the Lord will be lost from our life and from the church. If this occurs our relationship and work will become routine and we will be stressed out about the things of God. God wants a relationship with us that which is built on love rather than duty.

SEVEN CHURCHES THE CHURCH OF SMYRNA

TEXT: Revelation 2:8-11 (NKJV) *“And to the angel of the church in Smyrna write, ‘These things says the First and the Last, who was dead, and came to life:9 “I know your works, tribulation, and poverty (but you are rich); and I know the blasphemy of those who say they are Jews and are not, but are a synagogue of Satan.10 “Do not fear any of those things which you are about to suffer. Indeed, the devil is about to throw some of you into prison, that you may be tested, and you will have tribulation ten days. Be faithful until death, and I will give you the crown of life.11 “He who has an ear, let him hear what the Spirit says to the churches. He who overcomes shall not be hurt by the second death.”*”

INTRO: You will notice that of the seven churches that John addressed, he gave the least space to the church of Smyrna. He was able to cover everything he had to say about this church in just four verses. However, we must not think less of this church, or feel they were insignificant just because there are less verses about them. Why? There were only two of the seven churches that the Lord did not have words of condemnation for – the church of Philadelphia and, you guessed it, the Church of Smyrna. This church was a tremendous church, and the Lord did not have one bad thing to say about it.

Even though the Lord had no words of condemnation for the people of Smyrna the scripture tells us they were going through some very difficult times. [The church of Smyrna is known as the suffering church.](#) When people are suffering, they do not need words of condemnation, they need words of comfort. (My experience on TBN following the Katrina disaster) The Lord, knowing this, had nothing harsh to say about them.

All of those who have had to counsel people during difficult times in their lives know how difficult it is to say the right thing. The Lord Jesus is writing this personal letter Himself, and using John as the postman to deliver it to them to encourage them to continue serving Him.

Everything about the life of Christ is a lesson to us. From this letter that Christ sent to that suffering church we can learn a great deal about how to help people when they are suffering. As we study these four verses that deal with the church at Smyrna, we can see why they needed comfort...

I. THE CONTENTS...

In our study of the church at Ephesus we established that Ephesus was one of the most exciting places on earth to live at that time. But, Smyrna was one of the loveliest places to live. If you lived in Smyrna, you lived at the top of social totem pole.

In our study of the church of Ephesus we discovered that Ephesus was the Queen city of Asia. But, there are those who feel that Smyrna was the Queen city, and the people of Smyrna felt that way.

Archeologists have found coins from that area upon which the words, “*The first city of Asia*,” were inscribed.

We can best understand the picture of the competition between the people of these two cities when we compare them to two football teams that consider each other to be rivals. The people of Smyrna claimed their town was number one and in many ways Smyrna was number one. Let me tell you why:

- Smyrna was located only 35 miles north of Ephesus which means it had a good location...
- No one knows exactly when the church of Smyrna was started, but it was probably started when Paul was in Ephesus. He was there three years, and **Acts 19:10** says, “*....so that all they which dwelt in Asia heard the word of the Lord Jesus, both Jews and Greeks.*” Since Smyrna was only 35 miles away, we can safely assume that included them...
- Smyrna was originally founded as a Greek colony in 1000 B.C....
- It was later destroyed in 600 B.C....
- It was rebuilt by one of the great generals of Alexander the Great around 301-281 B.C....
- It was with great pride that the citizens of Smyrna would declare how their lovely city had once been destroyed, yet it was rebuilt even greater than it had been before...
- It was known for its large amphitheater that seated as many as twenty thousand at one time, which was extremely large for that day and time...

- Historians state it is the most beautiful city that the Greeks have ever built...
- It still exists... If you were to visit Turkey you would find it, now called Izmar. It has a population of 275,000 people.

Smyrna was referred to by many as the crown city, because it sat on the top of a beautiful hill and as ships approached from the sea the beautiful buildings looked like a crown on the top of that hill. It was probably because of this that the Lord Jesus reminded those Christians that one day they would not just live in a city which looked like a crown but He would give them a real crown!

Smyrna got its name from its chief export which was a gum-like resin taken from a shrub that was very bitter. This myrrh was used for four things:

- (1) It was used for making perfume – Psalms 45:8.
- (2) It was used for embalming – John 19:39.
- (3) It was used for the purification of women – Esther 2:12.
- (4) It was used for an anesthetic – Mark 15:23.

It was used three times in connection with the life of Christ:

- (1) His birth – Matt. 2:11.
- (2) His crucifixion – Mark 15:23
- (3) His burial – John 19:39.

As we look at the three times myrrh was connected to the life of Jesus we discover that each time it was used as a gift, anesthetic and for His burial.

It is also interesting to note that it is not mentioned in connection with the future coming of Christ. **Isaiah 60:6 (NKJV)** ***“The multitude of camels shall cover your land, The dromedaries of Midian and Ephah; All those from Sheba shall come; They shall bring gold and incense, And they shall proclaim the praises of the LORD.”*** When Christ was born He was presented with gold, frankincense and Myrrh. But, when Isaiah spoke of Christ’s returning, myrrh is not mentioned. Why? It is not mentioned because myrrh was used as an anesthetic. When Christ died on the cross it was administered because of His suffering. When He returns He will not be the suffering Christ (Savior), He is coming back as King of Kings and Lord of Lords and myrrh is not mentioned.

Smyrna comes from the word myrrh. Myrrh was the city's chief export and many of the people became very wealthy as they would crush the plant and extract its gum-like resin and ship it around the world to be used in the four ways we have mentioned.

Now, with these facts in mind, let us look at the church of Smyrna and see how the Smyrna Christians fit into that ritzy society.

II. THE CHURCH...

We must remember this letter was not written to the city of Smyrna, but to the church of Smyrna. Why was it written to the church? Because the people of the church could relate to the city that they lived in, a city that was proud of its culture, its beauty, its commercial wealth, and its social life. It was a city where everyone was trying to climb the social ladder. The Lord had this to say to the Christians in that culture:

- Verse 8, ***“These things saith the first and the last...”*** In other words, everyone in Smyrna was trying so hard to be first on the social ladder. But Jesus said that He was ***“.....the first and the last.....”*** That is, when that crowd has come and gone, He is still going to be here.
- In verse 10, Christ said, ***“I will give thee a crown of life.”*** In other words, *“Everyone in Smyrna thinks they are so rich and have so much to offer you but do not pay any attention to that crowd, I will give you a crown of life for your faithfulness.”* (Paraphrase)

Who would ever have thought that some of the cruelest things ever done to men were done to Christians in that lovely place?

We can drive by a lovely house and think it looks like a touch of heaven on earth. The house is beautiful. It is well maintained. The yard is immaculate. The trees sway in the breeze, and we say, *“My, what a lovely home. I would give anything to get to live there.”* Did you know that in that house, where you or I would love to live, someone might live who would give anything to be able to get out of there? That place may look good from the outside, but inside it could be filled with misery! Smyrna was like that.

The word, Smyrna, describes how the church was being crushed, like the herb was crushed to extract myrrh. The Christians faithfully served the Lord and would not denounce their faith and they were being tremendously persecuted. They, like the herb, were being crushed, and from their

persecution there rose up a sweet, sweet fragrance to enter the nostrils of God.

ILLUSTATION: There is a company that is well known for the perfume it produces. Often the employees go to a nearby town for lunch. When the workers from the plant go into town for lunch, those who wait on them can tell that they work at the perfume plant because the sweet smell of the perfume lingers on them.

People could identify the members of the Smyrna church by the sweet attitude they exuded as they were being crushed through persecution. Why were they being persecuted? They were being persecuted because of the simplicity of their worship.

Again, be reminded, Smyrna was a city for the affluent. The most beautiful, ornate architecture of the world at that time was there. Of all the seven cities that John addressed in Revelation, Smyrna was by far the most beautiful. In the city there were beautiful temples for worship, the Christians met in homes, or quietly worshiped under trees, even in catacombs. Their simplicity of worship was more than the sophisticated Jews could handle and this brought with it bitter persecution.

In the very affluent society where the Jews saw the simplicity of the Christians, their disgust for their own form of worship played a big part in their persecuting those Christians.

But, there is another, stronger, reason they persecuted them. It was because of emperor worship! Christians refused to participate in the emperor worship. What was emperor worship? In order to fully understand this concept you must understand a little about Roman government. Today we look back at history and we see the Roman government's cruelty. The Romans:

- Fed Christians to the lions in the coliseum...
- Caused Christians to be stoned, beaten, and jailed...
- Caused Christians to literally be burned at the stake...
- Were so corrupt they could be persuaded to execute innocent men...
- The Lord Jesus was crucified at the hands of the Roman government...

Often the heads of the Roman government were tyrants. The Roman government was one of the vilest governments that ever existed. That is how we see the Roman government.

But, if we are going to get what we are supposed to get from this letter, we're going to have to see the Roman government the way the majority of the citizens of that day saw it. What was their view of it? They considered the Roman government to be their great protector! How? The Roman government became so strong that no one dared to attack any of Rome's provinces.

ILLUSTRATION: When Ronald Reagan was commander-in-chief of this nation he believed in a strong military. His theory was that the best way to protect America is to become so strong that anyone would have to be a fool to try to attack us.

ILLUSTRATION: We know that hundreds of people across America are mugged each week. But, did you know that professional boxers, wrestlers, and professional linebackers never get mugged? Why? Even a mugger knows better than to pick on someone when he knows he can't win.

The reason I mention that is to show you the attitude of the people under Rome's rule. The Roman citizens saw the Roman government as a big brother that protected them from all of their enemies. If you were a citizen during that time you would not have had anything negative to say about the Roman government. You would have thought, *"I am thankful for the Roman government because it protects me from our enemies."*

The people began to think, *"We love this government so much, and we will worship the spirit of the Roman Empire."* Then they said, *"It is difficult to worship a spirit, so let us worship the personification of the spirit, who is the emperor."*

Out of patriotic pride they began to worship the emperor. It was more political than religious, but later the emperors felt that they had taken on divine attributes and Emperor Worship became mandatory. The Christian's refused to worship the emperor. They were simple minded in that they stated, *"We are Christians and we will bow only to the God of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob."*

III. THE CONFLICT...

When the Christians refused to bow, they became the targets for persecution because, the people of Smyrna could not imagine anyone being as unthankful and unpatriotic as to live under such a marvelous government and not want to bow to the emperors. These Christians were persecuted and tortured in just about any way you could imagine. Despite the persecution, these Christians took their stand and paid the price and the Lord had nothing but nice things to say to them.

The citizens of Smyrna lived affluent lifestyles but because of the intense persecution most of the Christians lived beneath the poverty line. These Christians thought themselves poor but look at what Jesus say's to them.

Revelation 2:9 (NKJV) ***"I know your works, tribulation, and poverty (but you are rich); and I know the blasphemy of those who say they are Jews and are not, but are a synagogue of Satan."***

Christians were torn asunder, boiled, beaten with whips, arms and legs amputated, and thrown alive into lion's dens while onlookers cheered. These Christians were accused of being children of the devil while the government and religious establishment claimed to be the true children of God! In the midst of this kind of persecution the Smyrna Christians clung to the words of Jesus for dear life. Matthew 5:11-12 (NKJV) ***"Blessed are you when they revile and persecute you, and say all kinds of evil against you falsely for My sake.12 Rejoice and be exceedingly glad, for great is your reward in heaven, for so they persecuted the prophets who were before you."***

In many of our churches we used to sing the song, *"It Will Be Worth It All When We See Jesus."* But these people knew the full meaning of the words!

IV. THE CROWN...

Jesus told the Smyrna Christians to continue to stand because as they endured persecution, rewards were being laid up in heaven for them. In The midst of such persecution notice what Jesus say's to them in verses 10 ***"Do not fear any of those things which you are about to suffer. Indeed, the devil is about to throw some of you into prison, that you may be tested, and you will have tribulation ten days. Be faithful until death, and I will give you the crown of life."***

God does not see things the way we see them. Evil people can look at each other in their fine homes and fine clothes and say, *"They are rich!"* We tend to look at those who do not possess much of this world's goods and say,

“They are poor!” But God sees things totally backwards from the way we see them. God can look at the rich man and say, *“you are poor,”* and He can look at the poor Christian and say, *“you are rich!”* **Genuine riches do not consist of the things we attain in this life but in how rich we are toward God.**

We often hear Christians say, *“I would like to be rich.”* What we often fail to recognize is that we who have accepted Christ are the richest people on this earth. We are heirs with Christ Jesus and the richest man on this earth is poor in comparison because the Christian has the peace of God in this earth and the riches of heaven waiting for him to enjoy for eternity. **Romans 8:14-17 (NKJV)** ***“For as many as are led by the Spirit of God, these are sons of God.15 For you did not receive the spirit of bondage again to fear, but you received the Spirit of adoption by whom we cry out, “Abba, Father.”16 The Spirit Himself bears witness with our spirit that we are children of God,17 and if children, then heirs—heirs of God and joint heirs with Christ, if indeed we suffer with Him, that we may also be glorified together.”***

CONCLUSION: The Christians who were a part of the church of Smyrna should serve as encouragement to those of us who are attempting to follow Christ. Their life should say to all of us that no matter what we must endure the *“Crown of life”* is worth the conflict.

ILLUSTRATION: An elderly pastor by the name of Polycarp was given the ultimatum of renouncing his faith or dying for his faith and he responded in the following manner, *“Eighty and six years have I served Him, and He never wronged me. How then shall I blaspheme my King Who saved me?”*

SEVEN CHURCHES THE CHURCH OF PERGAMOS

TEXT: Revelation 2:12-17 (NKJV) *“And to the angel of the church in Pergamos write, ‘These things says He who has the sharp two-edged sword: 13 “I know your works, and where you dwell, where Satan’s throne is. And you hold fast to My name, and did not deny My faith even in the days in which Antipas was My faithful martyr, who was killed among you, where Satan dwells. 14 “But I have a few things against you, because you have there those who hold the doctrine of Balaam, who taught Balak to put a stumbling block before the children of Israel, to eat things sacrificed to idols, and to commit sexual immorality. 15 “Thus you also have those who hold the doctrine of the Nicolaitans, which thing I hate. 16 ‘Repent, or else I will come to you quickly and will fight against them with the sword of My mouth. 17 “He who has an ear, let him hear what the Spirit says to the churches. To him who overcomes I will give some of the hidden manna to eat. And I will give him a white stone, and on the stone a new name written which no one knows except him who receives it.”*

INTRO: As we study these seven churches of Revelation, we can see something special in these scriptures. We can see that the Lord was always looking for something to compliment His church about. We must always remember that [God never looks for a reason to discipline us but for a reason to reward us.](#)

ILLUSTRATION: This looking for the good reminds us of the story of the man who asked a policeman how he liked his job. The policeman answered, *“Well, it is dangerous, and the pay is not so good.”* Then, being a good optimist, he added, *“But the customer is always wrong!”*

Regardless of what job you may have, or what situation you find yourself in, you can always find something good about everything if you really want to.

Wouldn’t it be wonderful if everyone who is associated with God’s church was such an optimist? If we follow the example of the Lord Jesus in the book of Revelation, we will always try to find something good about the church. We have too many today, in spite of the fact that the church has done so much good, who can only find bad things to say about God’s church.

ILLUSTRATION: (My experience of telling a church member he was a pessimist...) This reminds me of the panhandler who was on the streets begging for a handout. A man came along and had compassion on him and gave him enough money to buy a cup of hot coffee. The next day the man saw the panhandler on the street again. He asked, *“Did you enjoy the cup of coffee yesterday?”* The panhandler became very angry and said to him, *“No, I certainly did not. That cup of coffee kept me awake all night last night!”*

The way some people complain, you would think that they have never had any fair treatment in this life. When the pessimist smells flowers he looks around for a casket.

But, Jesus was always looking for something good to compliment His churches about, and the church of Pergamos is no different. The Lord had many wonderful things to say about this church. Look at some of the compliments, having to do with their faith, the Lord bestowed upon this church in Pergamos.

I. THE COMPLIMENT OF THEIR FAITH...

The Lord complimented the church of Pergamos for:

The Circumstances of their faith... Revelation 2:13 (NKJV) ***“I know your works, and where you dwell, where Satan’s throne is. And you hold fast to My name, and did not deny My faith even in the days in which Antipas was My faithful martyr, who was killed among you, where Satan dwells.”***

God describes Pergamos as the ***“seat of Satan.”*** That should put to rest the idea that Satan is in hell. In fact, it may shock you to hear this, but did you know that Satan does not presently reside in hell? 1 Peter 5:8 (NKJV) ***“Be sober, be vigilant; because your adversary the devil walks about like a roaring lion, seeking whom he may devour.”***

While often the church is divided and in chaos, the Bible tells us that Satan is organized and is accomplishing his purpose because Christians are asleep. They do not realize what he is doing! There is no doubt about the fact that Satan has conquered certain cities and claimed them as his headquarters.

ILLUSTRATION: Those who have listened to the late Dr. J. Vernon McGee have heard him say many times when he was alive, that he thought that *“Satan had made Los Angeles his headquarters in America.”* This could possibly be the case. Many have referred to this city as being the cesspool of America. That is because it is filled with people who are involved in all kinds of cults, and every kind of sin that is imaginable. Some refer to Los Angeles as Lust Angeles. Los Angeles is not the only wicked city in America; think about New Orleans; Las Vegas; San Francisco; all these cities are on the same level with Sodom and Gomorrah. What do you think of when someone says the names of one of these cities? Do you think of civic clubs, boy scouts, girl scouts, and churches? No! You think of gambling, prostitution, homosexuality, nudity, drinking, adultery, deception, lying, mafia, and cheating. Why? Because, everything we see and hear about these cities leads us to believe that it seems to exist for those reasons.

Satan has completely taken over many of the cities of America, and probably many of these are headquarters that he works out of. Before we feel too righteous, Houston is not the New Jerusalem either!

During the time of the church of Pergamos, the Bible states clearly that Pergamos was the headquarters of Satan. It was the most wicked and vile environment of that day.

Today, when Christians have to live in those conditions, we feel alone and feel that no one understands our situation. For example:

- Some may have to live in a wicked home environment. They are constantly exposed to arguments, cursing, lying and cheating. They come to church and are refreshed and leave feeling clean, but after they are home only a few short minutes they feel as if they have been drug through the mud.
- Some have to go to jobs every day where they hear men and women bragging about their infidelities. They hear people taking God's name in vain, and hear them tell sacrilegious and dirty jokes. It is difficult to work in that kind of environment when a person is a Christian.
- Some have to go to school and all day long they are exposed to ungodly teachers and students who are bent on doing evil.

Many feel like they dwell in “*Satan’s seat*,” and some of them may very well be! They know the strain of being in evil environments and often feel no one seems to understand.

But, look at what Christ said to the church that dwelt in such an evil environment. He said, “*I know where you dwell....*” He wanted the church of Pergamos to understand that He knew how difficult it was for a Christian to live in such an evil place. God knew the circumstances in which their faith was being developed. He also knows the circumstances in which our faith is being developed.

The Courage of their faith... Look again at verse 13 where it says, “...*You held fast to My name, and did not deny My faith...*” In that cesspool of sin, where people were consumed with the pleasures, comforts, and possessions of life there were some Christians who believed the Word of God and not only preached and taught it but lived by it in spite of the circumstances. Jesus commended those for they had “...*held fast to My name, and did not deny My faith...*” In those very trying circumstances the Christians had the courage to stand for the Lord.

Today’s world is in desperate need of Christians who have the courage to stand up for their faith in evil surroundings. The reason the world has become so wicked is because Christians have allowed their light to go out! The church has taken a back seat in the political processes because of a perceived separation between church and state. Separation of church and state was never intended to silence the church or kill its righteous influence; this has all been perpetrated by the liberal crowd in this country! Because the light of Christians have gone out and the church has been neutered by the political process:

- Homosexuals are coming out of the closet en masse... There was a time that sodomy was punishable with a prison term. Now the right to live this “*alternative lifestyle*” has been granted by the government! The Sodomites know the church is no longer a powerful force so they parade their abominable lifestyle publicly!
- Abortionists march openly claiming that women have the right to “*abort*” their children? There was a time when abortion was recognized for what it is, murder! The lack of influence the church wields in this culture manifested itself in this country through a law called Roe vs. Wade! The Supreme Court may say a woman has the

right to murder her baby, but God will still hold accountable those who commit such a crime against nature!

- [Trash television and the internet have accelerated the demise of the culture...](#) "Because the church of our Lord Jesus has become a joke and is mocked by most comedians on television, they televise their trash and have no Christian influence to stop them.

The real tragedy is that the church, which is supposed to be separated from the world, is so much a part of the world that Hollywood can televise, broadcast, or print anything they want to because so-called Christians watch, listen to, and read the same things the world does! What ever happened to God's church? Do we not have the love for our Lord Jesus that will cause us to have the courage to stand up for Him? We need to pray that we will have the courage that the Christians of Pergamos had.

Christians today seek employment and friends who share their values. This has resulted in the extraction of Christian influence from the marketplace, the workplace and even the home place! [We as Christian need to invade every sector of this society and let our lights shine!](#) This is what the church at Pergamos did! [Matthew 10:32-33 \(NKJV\)](#) ***"Therefore whoever confesses Me before men, him I will also confess before My Father who is in heaven.33 "But whoever denies Me before men, him I will also deny before My Father who is in heaven."*** [Mark 8:38 \(NKJV\)](#) ***"For whoever is ashamed of Me and My words in this adulterous and sinful generation, of him the Son of Man also will be ashamed when He comes in the glory of His Father with the holy angels."*** [2 Timothy 2:12 \(NKJV\)](#) ***"If we endure, We shall also reign with Him. If we deny Him, He also will deny us."***

These verses of scripture should cause everyone who professes to be saved, but does not stand up for their faith, some great concern. It should motivate all of us to pray for the courage and step out and speak up for Jesus.

[The Conviction of their faith...](#) [Revelation 2:13 \(NKJV\)](#) ***"I know your works, and where you dwell, where Satan's throne is. And you hold fast to My name, and did not deny My faith even in the days in which Antipas was My faithful martyr, who was killed among you, where Satan dwells."***

The church of Pergamos was under a lot of persecution. Perhaps there were others who were martyred also, but we know of one at least, by the name of Antipas. [A.T. Robertson's "Word Pictures in the New Testament, Vol VI, page 305](#), we are told that tradition has it that Antipas was *["Placed inside a](#)*

brazen bull and slowly roasted to death.” It was against this backdrop that the Christians of Pergamos were going counter culture to serve Christ! The people of the first century church knew that to be witnesses for Christ meant there was a good chance they would be martyred.

William Barclay said, *“In the early church, to be a martyr and to be a witness were one and the same thing. The early believers knew exactly what it meant to become followers of Christ; it meant the commitment of all they were and had. It meant the possibility of death.”*

When the first century Christians accepted Christ, they knew their faith might be the cause of their being put to death. That was why much of the teaching of Christ dealt with the suffering and possible death of those who would follow Him. Matthew 24:9 (NKJV) ***“Then they will deliver you up to tribulation and kill you, and you will be hated by all nations for My name’s sake.”*** The apostle Peter taught that suffering and death were a possibility for those who expressed faith in Christ. 1 Peter 4:12-13 (NKJV) ***“Beloved, do not think it strange concerning the fiery trial which is to try you, as though some strange thing happened to you;13 but rejoice to the extent that you partake of Christ’s sufferings, that when His glory is revealed, you may also be glad with exceeding joy.”*** The first century Christian believed they would die for their faith in Jesus.

ILLUSTRATION: On July 3, 1952, Captain Theodore Harris’ airplane caught on fire and he was badly burned. He had to parachute out and he landed in a Korean rice field. He was denied medical assistance; he had to live in sub-zero weather; he was tortured for fourteen months. They offered to stop if he would just sign a piece of paper that stated that the Americans had sent him on a mission to drop germs over Korea. He knew that was not true, and he refused to sign. In 1953 he was freed in an exchange of prisoners, but he had never once denied the truth.

Antipas, who could have been the pastor of the church of Pergamos, was called upon by the Emperor to denounce his faith in Christ. Antipas translated means, “Against all.” When he refused to denounce his faith in Christ, the Emperor would say, *“Everyone is against you.”* Antipas would answer, *“I am against everyone!”*

Every day, pressure is applied to every Christian to persuade them to conform to this world’s sinful ways. All of us should question ourselves

periodically whether or not we are compromising because this is a gradual process which overtakes us almost unnoticed.

II. THE CORRECTION OF THEIR FAITH...

The Lord had many wonderful things to say about the church at Pergamos and if had ended there, this would no doubt be an exemplary church. His words did not end there. [Revelation 2:14-15](#) (NKJV) ***“But I have a few things against you, because you have there those who hold the doctrine of Balaam, who taught Balak to put a stumbling block before the children of Israel, to eat things sacrificed to idols, and to commit sexual immorality.¹⁵ Thus you also have those who hold the doctrine of the Nicolaitans, which thing I hate.”***

We should always remember; the devil does not have one scheme for all churches; he knows what might cause one church to trip up might not work on the next church. The enemy was diligent to do his homework and discover what the church at Pergamos would be vulnerable to.

With the church of Pergamos Satan used compromise as a means of deceiving the church and getting them out of the will of God. This church eventually compromised and became a church full of corruption.

They began to allow preachers and teachers to dispense false doctrine without calling them into question. This did not happen overnight and probably was not a premeditated infraction. It was a gradual process! Compromise is always a gradual process, it can happen so gradually that it can go almost un-noticed.

This is exactly what America has done and Godly people have stood back and allowed it to transpire. The early Americans had clear cut principles, they established laws which:

- Permitted prayer in schools...
- Permitted the Ten Commandments in public buildings...
- Permitted public figures to openly discuss their faith without fear of reprisal...
- Outlawed same sex marriages and unions...
- Outlawed homosexuality...
- Outlawed the murder of unborn babies...

As a result the nation grew and prospered. As the population became apathetic the enemy sent influencers who would slowly erode the morals of the nation, then change its laws to allow for the sinful nature to be placed on a public platform.

What should we do? [2 John 10](#) (NKJV) ***"If anyone comes to you and does not bring this doctrine, do not receive him into your house nor greet him;"***

Instead of rejecting the false teachers and their false teachings, the church of Pergamos received them and became corrupted by them.

There is only one thing that can cure a corrupt church. [Revelation 2:12](#) (NKJV) ***"And to the angel of the church in Pergamos write, 'These things says He who has the sharp two-edged sword:'"*** The sharp sword is the Word of God. The Word is:

- [A devouring flame](#)... [Jeremiah 5:14](#) (NKJV) ***"Therefore thus says the LORD God of hosts: "Because you speak this word, Behold, I will make My words in your mouth fire, And this people wood, And it shall devour them."***
- [A crushing hammer](#)... [Jeremiah 23:29](#) (NKJV) ***"Is not My word like a fire?" says the LORD, "And like a hammer that breaks the rock in pieces?"***
- [A life-giving source](#)... [Ezekiel 37:7](#) (NKJV) ***"So I prophesied as I was commanded; and as I prophesied, there was a noise, and suddenly a rattling; and the bones came together, bone to bone."***
- [A Saving power](#)... [Romans 1:16](#) (NKJV) ***"For I am not ashamed of the gospel of Christ, for it is the power of God to salvation for everyone who believes, for the Jew first and also for the Greek."***
- [A defensive and offensive weapon](#)... [Ephesians 6:17](#) (NKJV) ***"And take the helmet of salvation, and the sword of the Spirit, which is the word of God;"***
- [A probing instrument](#)... [Hebrews 4:12](#) (NKJV) ***"For the word of God is living and powerful, and sharper than any two-edged sword, piercing even to the division of soul and spirit, and of joints and marrow, and is a discerner of the thoughts and intents of the heart."***

Look at how the Lord describes the corruption of the church at Pergamos. [Revelation 2:14](#) (NKJV) ***“But I have a few things against you, because you have there those who hold the doctrine of Balaam, who taught Balak to put a stumbling block before the children of Israel, to eat things sacrificed to idols, and to commit sexual immorality.”*** Always remember, you cannot mix pure doctrine with false doctrine. If you do, you have a corrupted church and this is exactly what had been allowed to happen at Pergamos. Instead of ***“trying”*** those who claimed to be apostles as the church of Ephesus did, they compromised and began to accept them.

One of the groups they accepted taught the doctrine of Balaam. To understand this, we have to go back to the Old Testament. There was a man who claimed to be a prophet and have an inside track to the many gods he claimed existed. For a certain price, Balaam would get favors from the god's for those who were willing to pay him. The king of Moab, Balac, wanted to defeat Israel, so he hired this prophet to curse Israel. But, every time he would curse them, they would prosper. He was not able to curse them, but he came up with a plan. If he could not curse them maybe he could corrupt them! He did that by getting the women of Moab to marry the men of Israel. Once they moved in, they began influencing the Jews to eat meat offered up to their idols, and eventually the Israelites began serving their gods.

[Churches are corrupted when false preachers and teachers are allowed to spew false doctrine which is accepted by many, and ignored by those who do not agree.](#) Once people such as this are granted entrance into the church they gradually lead the people down the slippery slope of counterfeit doctrine.

The Lord told the church at Pergamos that He had ***“somewhat”*** against them because they had compromised and had accepted the doctrine of Balaam. They had allowed a gradual erosion of the foundation of truth.

Look at [Revelation 2:15](#) (NKJV) ***“Thus you also have those who hold the doctrine of the Nicolaitans, which thing I hate.”*** This is the second time John wrote about this group. Remember, the Lord commended the church of Ephesus because they resisted this doctrine. [Revelation 2:6](#) (NKJV) ***“But this you have, that you hate the deeds of the Nicolaitans, which I also hate.”***

God said He hated what the Nicolaitanes stood for and He commended the church of Ephesus because they also hated what that group stood for. But, the church of Pergamos compromised and came to the place where they had allowed those who believed this doctrine to stay in their church. The word ***“hold”*** means they not only allowed this doctrine to be taught but actually defended it.

The word Nicolaitanes is not a translation, but a transliteration. It is two Greek words put together. “Nico,” means: “*To conquer.*” “Laitanes,” is the word for laity, and means: “*the laity.*” The Nicolaitanes taught that there is a division between the clergy and the laity of the church. The doctrine of the Nicolaitanes taught the need for a priest as a go-between for man and God. This elevated the clergy to the role of priesthood and reduced the role of laity to those who could not hear from God. The New Testament teaches that everyone who is a child of God is a New Testament Priest. That is, as a clergyman, I do not have any more favor with God than you do.

Even though we do not believe in the necessity of a human priest we often operate in the same way as those who do. When tragedy strikes, the first thing that comes to people’s minds is, “*someone call the preacher!*” While any good pastor is always available to help in time of tragedy, let me make one thing clear; if you are living a holy life, you have as much influence with God as I do!

III. THE CURE OF THEIR FAITH...

The church of Pergamos was in desperate need of spiritual surgery. This surgery must be performed by the scalpel of the Word of God and the determined hand of church leaders. The only thing that can cure the cancer of compromise which has infiltrated the church is the Word of God and church leaders who have the nerve to stand against the tide of public opinion:

- Revelation 2:16 (NKJV) ***“Repent, or else I will come to you quickly and will fight against them with the sword of My mouth.”*** God said He is not going to allow the spirit of compromise to continue in His church, He is going to fight against it, “... ***with the sword of His mouth.***” You see, Christ does not have to achieve victory with missiles and tanks, all He has to do is speak the Word and the rebellious are defeated!

- Revelation 2:17 (NKJV) ***“He who has an ear, let him hear what the Spirit says to the churches. To him who overcomes I will give some of the hidden manna to eat. And I will give him a white stone, and on the stone a new name written which no one knows except him who receives it.”*** He tells those who are truly saved that if they will take a stand against the doctrine of Balaam and the doctrine of the Nicolaitanes and not eat at their altars, or the bread offered up to their idols, He will do two things:
 1. ***“I will give to eat of the hidden manna...”*** What did He mean by ***“hidden manna?”*** In the Old Testament when the Children of Israel were hungry, God fed them mysteriously with ***“hidden manna.”*** The Lord has ***“hidden manna”*** for those who are following Him, and in some mysterious way He always provides what they need. God was telling the church of Pergamos that *if they would quit relying upon the world meet their needs, He would take care of them.*
 2. ***“I will give him a white stone, and in the stone a new name written, which no man knoweth, saving he that receiveth it...”*** There has been a lot of speculation about this white stone, but *most commentators believe this means it is a signet of admission into heaven.* Heaven is not promised based on church affiliation, but on relationship with the Father through the Son. One of the glorious things about being saved is that we do not have to wonder or hope; we can know positively that we are children of God. If we are His children then we are his heirs and heaven belongs to Him, so it belongs to us!

CONCLUSION: We should take a lesson from the church of Pergamos and refuse to compromise our beliefs. If we will do this we will experience God’s protection and provision, we can also be assured of Heaven as our reward.

SONGS: *“Hold to God’s unchanging hand.” “On Christ the solid rock I stand, all other ground is sinking sand.”*

SEVEN CHURCHES THE CHURCH OF THYATIRA

TEXT: Revelation 2:18-29 (NKJV) *“And to the angel of the church in Thyatira write, ‘These things says the Son of God, who has eyes like a flame of fire, and His feet like fine brass: 19 “I know your works, love, service, faith,^[a] and your patience; and as for your works, the last are more than the first. 20 Nevertheless I have a few things against you, because you allow^[b] that woman^[c] Jezebel, who calls herself a prophetess, to teach and seduce^[d] My servants to commit sexual immorality and eat things sacrificed to idols. 21 And I gave her time to repent of her sexual immorality, and she did not repent.^[e] 22 Indeed I will cast her into a sickbed, and those who commit adultery with her into great tribulation, unless they repent of their^[f] deeds. 23 I will kill her children with death, and all the churches shall know that I am He who searches the minds and hearts. And I will give to each one of you according to your works. 24 “Now to you I say, and^[g] to the rest in Thyatira, as many as do not have this doctrine, who have not known the depths of Satan, as they say, I will^[h] put on you no other burden. 25 But hold fast what you have till I come. 26 And he who overcomes, and keeps My works until the end, to him I will give power over the nations— 27 ‘ He shall rule them with a rod of iron; They shall be dashed to pieces like the potter’s vessels’^[i]— as I also have received from My Father; 28 and I will give him the morning star. 29 “He who has an ear, let him hear what the Spirit says to the churches.”*

INTRO: In studying these seven churches, we discover they were established after the resurrection of the Lord Jesus Christ. When the first century Christians witnessed the crucifixion of Jesus on the cross all their hopes and dreams of a Kingdom with Christ in control were destroyed. When He arose from the grave, this epic event sent a tsunami of excitement through Christians around the world. There is absolutely nothing in the history of mankind that is any more exciting than the resurrection of Christ. In fact [the resurrection of Jesus from the dead is the most important event in the history of the world.](#) 1 Corinthians 15:17 (KJV) *“If Christ be not raised, your faith is vain; ye are yet in your sins.”*

If the crucifixion and resurrection of Jesus were to be looked at as the conception of the New Testament Church, [Pentecost is the birthday of the church.](#) Acts 2:1-4 (NKJV) *“When the Day of Pentecost had fully come,*

they were all with one accord^[a] in one place. 2 And suddenly there came a sound from heaven, as of a rushing mighty wind, and it filled the whole house where they were sitting. 3 Then there appeared to them divided tongues, as of fire, and one sat upon each of them. 4 And they were all filled with the Holy Spirit and began to speak with other tongues, as the Spirit gave them utterance.” Mark 16:17-20 (KJV) “These signs shall follow them that believe; In my name shall they cast out devils; they shall speak with new tongues; 18They shall take up serpents; and if they drink any deadly thing, it shall not hurt them; they shall lay hands on the sick, and they shall recover. 19So then after the Lord had spoken unto them, he was received up into heaven, and sat on the right hand of God. 20And they went forth, and preached every where, the Lord working with them, and confirming the word with signs following. Amen.”

If you will notice, the churches all started off good, but we see spiritual erosion in most of them over a period of time. The church of Thyatira was no exception. [As Jesus spoke to this church He revealed five things they were to be commended for:](#)

- [Works...](#) This church was an industrious church, it was not a lazy church by any means. Works are fine, but we are not saved by our works. [Ephesians 2:8-9](#) (KJV) *“For by grace you have been saved through faith, and that not of yourselves; it is the gift of God, 9 not of works, lest anyone should boast.”*
- [Charity...](#) This church was a loving church. We are commanded to be a loving church. The church should love the world... [John 3:16](#) (NKJV) *“For God so loved the world that He gave His only begotten Son, that whoever believes in Him should not perish but have everlasting life.”* The church should love one another... [1 John 3:14](#) (KJV) *“We know that we have passed from death unto life, because we love the brethren. He that loveth not his brother abideth in death.”*
- [Service...](#) This church was a church which was committed to serving its generation. The church should be serving the world with the love of Christ. [Matthew 25:35-40](#) (KJV) *“For I was an hungred, and ye gave me meat: I was thirsty, and ye gave me drink: I was a stranger, and ye took me in: 36Naked, and ye clothed me: I was sick, and ye visited me: I was in prison, and ye came unto me. 37Then shall the righteous answer him, saying, Lord, when saw we thee an hungred, and fed thee? or thirsty, and gave thee drink? 38When saw we thee a*

stranger, and took thee in? or naked, and clothed thee? 39Or when saw we thee sick, or in prison, and came unto thee? 40And the King shall answer and say unto them, Verily I say unto you, Inasmuch as ye have done it unto one of the least of these my brethren, ye have done it unto me.”

- [Faith...](#) This church was a church of deep seeded faith in Christ... They not only had saving faith, they had faith to do wonders... [James 2:17-18](#) (KJV) *“Even so faith, if it hath not works, is dead, being alone. 18Yea, a man may say, Thou hast faith, and I have works: shew me thy faith without thy works, and I will shew thee my faith by my works.”*
- [Patience...](#) This was a patient church... They did not let the events of the world around them to destroy the patience... [Hebrews 10:36](#) (KJV) *“For ye have need of patience, that, after ye have done the will of God, ye might receive the promise.”*

The trouble with this church is that at some point it began to attempt to negotiate the slippery slope of compromise and failed to properly negotiate its dangerous pitfalls. [Satan was threatened by the Church of Thyatira because it was a church on a mission.](#) They not only had a mission, they were accomplishing their mission. He set out to destroy this church and his method was through compromise. [He began to tempt them to substitute truth for error.](#)

Let us look more closely at this church that compromised. Look at....

[I. THE SOURCE OF THE COMPROMISE...](#)

[Revelation 2:20](#) (KJV) *“Notwithstanding I have a few things against thee, because thou sufferest (allow) that woman Jezebel, which calleth herself a prophetess, to teach and to seduce my servants to commit fornication, and to eat things sacrificed unto idols.”*

The source of the problem was a wicked woman in the church. The Bible refers to her as Jezebel because she was so much like the Old Testament Jezebel who was one of the vilest women who ever lived. She even set up the worship of Baal, and led God’s people away from Him. The Old Testament Jezebel combined the altar of Jehovah with the altar of Baal. The one thing more dangerous than worshipping a false god is to make an

attempt to marry the two together and this is what was happening in this church.

The teachings of the [cults](#) are still hated by God for the same reason they [attempt to combine Christianity with false teachings](#). That is, if you were to talk to a cultist, he would not start off his presentation with false teaching. He would begin by quoting scriptures that you are probably familiar with. For example, many people are surprised when Mormons come to their homes and talk about Jesus. The Mormons are quick to tell you that they believe in Jesus, but what they will never tell you is that the Jesus they believe in is not the Jesus of the Bible. (My experience with the Mormons) The Jesus they believe in is a man who once was like we are, but whom, through his good works became who he is and God placed him as ruler over planet earth. They also teach that if we do well, God will give us our own planet to rule the way Jesus rules. The Bible does not teach that! The Bible teaches the deity of Christ. [Jesus did not become good; He was God from the beginning! Hebrews 13:8 \(KJV\)](#) ***“Jesus Christ is the same yesterday, today, and forever.”***

The [woman](#) who was causing the trouble in the church of Thyatira was [mixing false teachings with Christianity](#) and was seducing many of God's servants. By tugging on the heart-strings of emotion, Jezebel was doing things contrary to the Word of God and no one seemed willing to stop her.

Notice, the Bible says this woman called herself a prophetess. God did not call her, she called herself. Evidently she felt this would gain her credibility. God said she was allowed to teach and seduce His servants to commit spiritual fornication and eat meat offered to idols.

The spirit of Jezebel can be identified by the following characteristics:

- [Know](#) it all...
- [Gossip](#)...
- [Anger](#)...
- [Un-forgiveness](#)...
- Source of [strife](#)...
- Over-riding [authority](#)...
- [Seared](#) conscience...
- [Manipulation](#)...
- [Blaming](#) others...

II. THE STUBBORNNESS...

Revelation 2:21 (KJV) ***"I gave her space to repent of her fornication; and she repented not."*** All of us should be thankful that God is not a hot-head, like some of us are. God does not have a short fuse. He is a patient God. He says that He had given the church of Thyatira, ***".....a space..."*** or a time to repent but they had not. The thing that would have pleased the Lord would have been for that church to come to their senses and refuse to have anything to do with the seducer who was called Jezebel.

When anyone makes a vicious attack on God's church, God makes it clear that He does not expect us to condone the evil by associating with that person. Look what He says:

- Titus 3:10 (NKJV) ***"Reject (weithdraw from) a divisive man after the first and second admonition."***
- 2 John 10-11 (NKJV) ***"If anyone comes to you and does not bring this doctrine, do not receive him into your house nor greet him; 11 for he who greets him shares in his evil deeds."***
- Romans 16:17 (NKJV) ***"Now I urge you, brethren, note (Mark) those who cause divisions and offenses, contrary to the doctrine which you learned, and avoid them."***
- 1 Corinthians 5:11 (KJV) ***"But now I have written unto you not to keep company, if any man that is called a brother be a fornicator, or covetous, or an idolator, or a railer, or a drunkard, or an extortioner; with such an one no not to eat."***

What are all of these verses of scripture teaching? They are teaching that Satan knows that one of the best ways to destroy a church is to send someone into its midst who is walking contrary to the Word of God and get the people to follow him instead of following the church leadership or the Lord. When a church experiences a split usually one or two, if not more, people have gotten another handful of Christians wrapped around their little fingers, and they demand to rule or ruin the church. Sadly the latter is usually the case. Usually the lead church troublemaker is a person who has proclaimed that they are super spiritual and know the Bible better than anyone else.

Now, the same Bible that tells me to love you and tells you to care for me is the same Bible that tells me that when one opposes God's Word or brings

discord into the church we are to ***“Reject; do not receive; do not greet; mark; avoid; do not keep company with; do not eat with;”*** those individuals including those who side with them.

In such a scenario, the Pastor is usually called upon to lead the charge to rid the church of such things. When he attempts to do this he is often accused of everything from being mean spirited to attempting to assume dictatorial control over a church. We must remember that **the Pastor is the under-shepherd and as such he is responsible for what is allowed to transpire in the church.** He will answer to God for what he allows!

ILLUSTRATION: God deals very harshly with those who attempt to mess up His family. **We would not show much consideration for those who are bent on making trouble in, or messing up our family and God takes a pretty dim view of it as well.** Proverbs 6:16-19 (KJV) ***“These six things doth the LORD hate: yea, seven are an abomination unto him: 17A proud look, a lying tongue, and hands that shed innocent blood, 18An heart that deviseth wicked imaginations, feet that be swift in running to mischief, 19A false witness that speaketh lies, and he that soweth discord among brethren.”*** I am convinced God has reserved a special place in hell for church trouble makers.

The best way I know of to get in trouble with God is to attack His church. Why? Because **the church, as imperfect as it may be, is the only institution that God has ordained to carry out the mission of reaching the lost world for Christ** and when you attack His church, you are attacking Him! When the church is attacked in this manner some of Gods sheep leave the fold, never to return. The church acquires a reputation that is tough to impossible to live down. As a result, the lost witness the internal struggles and lose confidence in the church and continue in their lost condition.

The Christians in Thyatira were stubborn and refused to rid itself of **“Jezebel”** and God decided to bring judgment upon them.

III. THEIR SENTENCE...

Revelation 2:22 (KJV) ***“Behold, I will cast her into a bed, and them that commit adultery with her into great tribulation, except they repent of their deeds.”*** Having been given sufficient time to repent, their stubborn refusal led to the pronouncement of Gods judgment.

Many today profess to be Christians but are living contrary to what the Word of God teaches. We should never forget that [sin always leads to judgment](#). If we refuse Gods [mercy](#), we can count on His [judgment](#).

The church which allows false doctrines to be taught and carnal people to control can prepare to suffer the consequences. [Galatians 6:6-8](#) (NKJV) ***“Let him who is taught the word share in all good things with him who teaches. 7 Do not be deceived, God is not mocked; for whatever a man sows, that he will also reap. 8 For he who sows to his flesh will of the flesh reap corruption, but he who sows to the Spirit will of the Spirit reap everlasting life.”***

We should always remember, the effects of our actions never stop with us, but continue on for additional [generations](#). [Revelation 2:22-23](#) (KJV) ***“Behold, I will cast her into a bed, and them that commit adultery with her into great tribulation, except they repent of their deeds. 23And I will kill her children with death; and all the churches shall know that I am he which searcheth the reins and hearts: and I will give unto every one of you according to your works.”***

The children that are mentioned in the church of Thyatira had been raised under the evil influence of Jezebel because the adult Christians allowed her to remain among them. [The children of Thyatira grew to believe such behavior was normal and would allow even worse things to transpire in their generation](#). If we allow such things to transpire in our generation our children and grandchildren will pay the price.

We cannot shake our fists in God’s face and get away with it. He will give us time to make things right, but if we do not, he knows exactly what it takes to get our attention and will stop at nothing to get us to repent.

CONCLUSION: Not everyone in the church of Thyatira was [seduced](#) by the sinfulness which had been allowed to go on in this church. [Rev 2:24-29](#) (KJV) ***“But unto you I say, and unto the rest in Thyatira, as many as have not this doctrine, and which have not known the depths of Satan, as they speak; I will put upon you none other burden. 25But that which ye have already hold fast till I come. 26And he that overcometh, and keepeth my works unto the end, to him will I give power over the nations: 27And he shall rule them with a rod of iron; as the vessels of a potter shall they be***

broken to shivers: even as I received of my Father. 28And I will give him the morning star. 29He that hath an ear, let him hear what the Spirit saith unto the churches.”

God always has a remnant in every generation who will follow His directives. I want to be one of those people in this generation.

SONG: *“I’m One Of Them.”*

SEVEN CHURCHES

THE CHURCH OF SARDIS

TEXT: Revelation 3:1-6 (NKJV) *“And to the angel of the church in Sardis write, ‘These things says He who has the seven Spirits of God and the seven stars: “I know your works, that you have a name that you are alive, but you are dead.”2 “Be watchful, and strengthen the things which remain, that are ready to die, for I have not found your works perfect before God.”3 “Remember therefore how you have received and heard; hold fast and repent. Therefore if you will not watch, I will come upon you as a thief, and you will not know what hour I will come upon you.”4 “You have a few names even in Sardis who have not defiled their garments; and they shall walk with Me in white, for they are worthy.”5 “He who overcomes shall be clothed in white garments, and I will not blot out his name from the Book of Life; but I will confess his name before My Father and before His angels.”6 “He who has an ear, let him hear what the Spirit says to the churches.”*

INTRO: We have come to the fifth of the seven churches, the church of Sardis. When we write a personal letter we conclude it by signing our name at the bottom. That lets the one we are writing to know who we are. But, when the Lord writes this letter to the Sardis membership, He tells them up front, Who He is! Revelation 3:1 (NKJV) *“And to the angel of the church in Sardis write, ‘These things says He who has the seven Spirits of God and the seven stars...’”*

The church of Sardis could be classified as a typical American church; they perceived themselves as a lively church, but the Lord saw this as a dead church! Revelation 3:1 (NKJV) *“...I know your works, that you have a name that you are alive, but you are dead.”*

Sometimes humans find it difficult to distinguish between a dead church and a church which is alive. There are two kinds of dead churches:

- The dead church that we are most familiar with is the church that has gone through the same rituals for the last fifty years. You can predict what will be happening by the time on the clock! As soon as you walk into a church like this, you know that God has long since departed the premises.

- The dead church that fools us is the one which has been camouflaged with all kinds of exciting programs which make it appear to be alive. It gives the appearance of being alive but it is dead!

I believe the latter to be the case with the church of Sardis.

ILLUSTRATION: When I first went to Pastor a certain church it was a very formal, traditional church. One Sunday I made this statement during the course of my sermon *“This is a dead church. This church is twice dead and plucked up by the roots!”* I knew as soon as I said it that the statement did not go over well. The next week a certain church leader came to see me and told me that *“Some of the church members were offended”* by my statement. He also said that he *“Did not believe the church was dead.”* I asked him to name the last person who was saved in the church and of course he could not tell me! I asked him to name the last person he could recall being baptized in the Holy Spirit. Again, he could not give me an answer! I asked him to name the last person who had experienced a healing in the church. Of course, he could not tell me! Finally I asked him what markers should be looked at to determine whether a church was dead or alive. Again, he could not answer!

When a person dies their vital signs prove they are dead! When a church dies its vital signs point up the fact that it is dead! [The vital signs of the church are...](#)

- [Salvations...](#)
- [Holy Spirit baptisms...](#)
- [Healings...](#)
- [Discipleship and deployment into ministry...](#)

[Mark 16:17-18 \(NKJV\)](#) ***“And these signs will follow those who believe: In My name they will cast out demons; they will speak with new tongues;18 “they will take up serpents; and if they drink anything deadly, it will by no means hurt them; they will lay hands on the sick, and they will recover.”***

When a church appears to be dead, the first place you should look for signs of life is the [Pastor](#). Remember, the letters to each of the seven churches is being addressed to the Pastor. [Revelation 3:1 \(NKJV\)](#) ***“And to the angel of the church in Sardis write...”*** The Lord knows there is little hope to resuscitating a church until the Pastor has been successfully rejuvenated! The Lord is writing directly to the pastor of the church of Sardis to challenge

him on this matter so he can, in return, revive the church. The pastor is always a determining factor that has to be considered before revival can take place. [A church will never rise above its leadership.](#)

[Sardis was a city made up of two sections.](#) The original section was developed on a level area about fifteen hundred feet up the side of a mountain. It was next to impossible for any enemy to penetrate their security and attack them. When the city outgrew the real estate available on the side of the mountain, the second section was built at the base of the mountain, in the valley below.

In spite of the fact that Sardis was almost impregnable, the city was captured twice. There was only one place where the enemy could possibly get into the city. [Both times Sardis was captured, the guards were asleep.](#) The same thing had happened to the church of Sardis. [Because the men and women of God were asleep, the devil was able to sneak in and invade and conquer God's church.](#) They certainly could relate to what the Lord said in Revelation 3:3 (NKJV) ***"Remember therefore how you have received and heard; hold fast and repent. Therefore if you will not watch, I will come upon you as a thief, and you will not know what hour I will come upon you."***

I. THE REPUTATION OF THE CHURCH...

If anyone moved to Sardis and asked, *"Where is the liveliest church in town,"* they probably would have been pointed to this particular church. [Just because a church is known for something in their past does not make it so in the present.](#) Some churches should be sued for false advertising; they claim to be Pentecostal when they are anything but a Pentecostal church! [Just because a person has been given a name does not necessarily mean they will live up to their initial billing!](#) The name Jabez means pain but he was determined not to live up to his name! 1 Chronicles 4:9-10 (NKJV) ***"Now Jabez was more honorable than his brothers, and his mother called his name Jabez, saying, "Because I bore him in pain."***¹⁰ ***And Jabez called on the God of Israel saying, "Oh, that You would bless me indeed, and enlarge my territory, that Your hand would be with me, and that You would keep me from evil, that I may not cause pain!"*** So ***God granted him what he requested.***

ILLUSTRATION: Sis. Violet Solberg is one of the kindest, gentlest women I have ever known but I always tease her about being the meanest

woman in the church! I tell her that her name should have had an N in it! (VioleNt)

The church of Sardis was known for being alive when they were anything but alive! Often we see churches with names like Unity, Harmony, Charity, etc., and the name seems fine, but sometimes after you have attended a few of their services you discover something very different.

ILLUSTRATION: The church of Sardis reminds me of the story of a country church that was called “*Rattle Snake Ridge Baptist Church.*” The church inherited a substantial sum of money and with the extra revenue they decided to do some extensive renovations; new carpet; new pews; a steeple; new paint; a general facelift. When they completed the project, they decided it looked so wonderful that it was time for a name change. They walked through the process of a name change and decided on the name, to “*First Baptist Church of Serpent’s Heights.*”

We are known by our names. Shakespeare asked, “*What’s in a name?*” A name can say a lot about what is going on inside or it can say a lot about what has gone on inside! A name is synonymous with the reputation. Proverbs 22:1 (NKJV) “***A good name is to be chosen rather than great riches...***” Ecclesiastes 7:1 (NKJV) “***A good name is better than precious ointment...***”

Everyone has a reputation, good or bad, and the church of Sardis had a reputation for being alive, but it was really they were dead!

II. THE REMAINS OF THE CHURCH...

When something dies, all you have left is the remains. When you go to a funeral, that person is not there only the remains are there. 2 Corinthians 5:1 (NKJV) “***For we know that if our earthly house, this tent, is destroyed, we have a building from God, a house not made with hands, eternal in the heavens.***”

The church of Sardis had lost all signs of life and the Lord pronounced them dead. What happens at the time of death?

- The senses depart... When a person dies, his senses die also. When we die, we become insensitive to our surroundings. We are not able to feel, taste, smell, see, or hear. You can go into many churches and not feel a thing. Why? The church is dead. There are other churches

you can go into and you can feel the presence of God. Why? Because it is alive!

- **The strength departs...** When a person is at the point of death he gets so weak he can hardly pick his hand up. Once he dies, all strength departs. No matter how strong or active the person was in life, when they are dead they have no strength! When a church dies, it loses its spiritual power. Samson lost his strength and the Bible says he, ***“....wist not that the Spirit of the Lord had departed from Him.”*** The church of Sardis was very active. They had a program for everything, but they were dead. They had many activities, but physical activity is not a sign of spiritual life. You can cut the head off of a snake, and you will still see all kinds of activity. Some might believe the snake is still alive, but the snake is dead, its muscles are in their death throes. We are told by scientists that the Polar Star's light takes 33 years to get to our earth. That means the Polar Star could have burned out thirty-three years ago and we would just now be realizing it!
- **The Spirit departs...** When a person dies, their spirit departs. ***Ecclesiastes 12:7 (NKJV) “Then the dust will return to the earth as it was, And the spirit will return to God who gave it.”*** The life of any church is the Holy Spirit. When He departs from a church, all you have left is death and a semblance of what used to be. The reason this is true is because the Holy Spirit is the direction and power of the church. ***John 16:13 (NKJV) “However, when He, the Spirit of truth, has come, He will guide you into all truth; for He will not speak on His own authority, but whatever He hears He will speak; and He will tell you things to come.”*** ***Acts 1:8 (NKJV) “But you shall receive power when the Holy Spirit has come upon you; and you shall be witnesses to Me in Jerusalem, and in all Judea and Samaria, and to the end of the earth.”*** Many churches have made it clear that they do not want the Holy Spirit operating in their presence. They have replaced the power of the Holy Spirit with ritual. This is what God's Word warned would happen, especially in the last days. ***2 Timothy 3:5 (NKJV) “Having a form of godliness but denying its power. And from such people turn away!”***

Many churches are like the church in Sardis, they have a reputation from yesteryear of being alive, but it is no more than a faint memory of days gone by.

ILLUSTRATION: A little girl was asked to bring her birth certificate to school. It was needed to complete her school records. It fell out of her back pack as she was on the way to school. When she got to school and realized it was gone she began crying. A teacher saw her and asked what was wrong? Because she had been accustomed to bringing notes to excuse her absence or tardiness she said, *“I have lost my excuse for being born!”*

That is exactly what happens to **many churches**. They **have no excuse, much less a reason, for being born**. They are dead!

III. THE RESTORATION OF THE CHURCH...

Revelation 3:3 (NKJV) ***“Remember therefore how you have received and heard; hold fast and repent...”***

Remember, the church of Sardis looked like it was alive because it was an active church. **We should never mistake activity for spirituality!** This church was going through all the rituals of worship, but their hearts were not in it. **Matthew 15:8-9 (NKJV) *“These people draw near to Me with their mouth, And honor Me with their lips, But their heart is far from Me. 9 And in vain they worship Me, Teaching as doctrines the commandments of men.”***

In spite of the deadness of their condition **God** saw a little spark of life and He **was trying to nurse the church of Sardis back to life by admonishing them to do four things:**

- **Watch...** Revelation 3:2 (NKJV) ***“Be watchful, and strengthen the things which remain, that are ready to die, for I have not found your works perfect before God.”*** In other words stay awake! (The five wise and five foolish virgins) **Revelation 16:15 (KJV) *“Behold, I come as a thief. Blessed is he that watcheth, and keepeth his garments, lest he walk naked, and they see his shame.”***
- **Strengthen...** Revelation 3:2 (NKJV) ***“Be watchful, and strengthen the things which remain, that are ready to die, for I have not found your works perfect before God.”*** This is a warning against apathy. How do you strengthen yourself? You force yourself to exercise your muscles. The only spiritual exercise some Christians get is going to and from church! Spiritual exercises which strengthen us are; prayer; reading the Word; fellowship of other believers; church attendance; and serving in ministry. The cry of the modern church is, *“Help, I’m on a pew and can’t get up!”*

- **Remember...** Revelation 3:3 (NKJV) ***“Remember therefore how you have received and heard; hold fast and repent. Therefore if you will not watch, I will come upon you as a thief, and you will not know what hour I will come upon you.”*** What were they being encouraged to remember? Remember the place from which they had fallen. This would give them a point of reference to which they could compare themselves. They were being told to remember their previous devotion to God; their previous passion for His presence: Their previous desire to serve Him by participating in a ministry they were called to.
- **Repent...** Revelation 3:3 (NKJV) ***“Remember therefore how you have received and heard; hold fast and repent. Therefore if you will not watch, I will come upon you as a thief, and you will not know what hour I will come upon you.”*** Repentance is the first mile of the road to revival. Repentance consists of recognizing our failure; admitting the part we played in the failure; and turning from the action that allowed the failure in the first place.

The church of Sardis is being warned that if they do not listen to these cautions they will be terminated as a church.

Remember, the city of Sardis was conquered twice because the guards were asleep. The church whose leadership is asleep at the wheel is doomed to repeat the history of Sardis.

These people are being admonished to awaken from their sleep and correct the error of their ways. God always stands ready for His people and church to step out of the shadows of compromise into the wonderful light of His perfect will. Listen to what Paul told Timothy. 2 Timothy 1:6 (NKJV) ***“Therefore I remind you to stir up the gift of God which is in you through the laying on of my hands.”***

IV. THE REMNANT OF THE CHURCH...

As bad as the situation in Sardis seemed, there was a remnant of people who were holding fast to the way's of the Lord. They were faithfully serving the Lord and praying for Him to send revival. Revelation 3:4 (NKJV) ***“You have a few names even in Sardis who have not defiled their garments; and they shall walk with Me in white, for they are worthy.”***

The remnant in Sardis had not “*defiled themselves*” and were still clinging to the way of righteousness. God always has and always will have a remnant that will follow Him! Songs: “*I’m Glad I Can Say I’m One of Them*” “*I’m So Glad I’m A Part of the Family of God*”

In the church of Sardis, where the majority of professing Christians were going through meaningless rituals week after week, there was a remnant that remained on the right track spiritually. Revelation 3:4-6 (NKJV) “*You have a few names even in Sardis who have not defiled their garments; and they shall walk with Me in white, for they are worthy.*”⁵ “*He who overcomes shall be clothed in white garments, and I will not blot out his name from the Book of Life; but I will confess his name before My Father and before His angels.*”⁶ “*He who has an ear, let him hear what the Spirit says to the churches.*”

CONCLUSION: I would rather be the Lords remnant than the devils majority! God and the Christian are a majority against the devil and the world!

SEVEN CHURCHES THE CHURCH OF PHILADELPHIA

TEXT: Revelation 3:7-13 (NKJV) “And to the angel of the church in Philadelphia write, ‘These things says He who is holy, He who is true, “He who has the key of David, He who opens and no one shuts, and shuts and no one opens”:⁸ “I know your works. See, I have set before you an open door, and no one can shut it; for you have a little strength, have kept My word, and have not denied My name.⁹ “Indeed I will make *those* of the synagogue of Satan, who say they are Jews and are not, but lie—indeed I will make them come and worship before your feet, and to know that I have loved you.¹⁰ “Because you have kept My command to persevere, I also will keep you from the hour of trial which shall come upon the whole world, to test those who dwell on the earth.¹¹ “Behold, I am coming quickly! Hold fast what you have, that no one may take your crown.¹² “He who overcomes, I will make him a pillar in the temple of My God, and he shall go out no more. And I will write on him the name of My God and the name of the city of My God, the New Jerusalem, which comes down out of heaven from My God. And *I will write on him* My new name.¹³ “He who has an ear, let him hear what the Spirit says to the churches.”

INTRO: The churches of Philadelphia and Smyrna were two churches that the Lord Jesus did not have any words of condemnation for. Does this mean they were perfect? Absolutely not! There can be no such thing as a perfect church as long as the membership is made up of mortals.

The church of Philadelphia was not perfect but was a very mature church on a spiritual level. Because of this God did not find anything to condemn them for. They were exactly where they were supposed to be, spiritually.

There are four interesting facts that need to be considered before we can appreciate some of the things the Lord had to say to this church:

- The name of the church... The word “**Philadelphia**” means: “*Brotherly love, or one who loves his brother.*” The name of this church is a constant reminder that they were doing what they had been instructed to do, loving each other. 1 John 3:14 (NKJV) “***We know that we have passed from death to life, because we love the brethren. He who does not love his brother abides in death.***”

- **The location of this church...** The location of this church was over a large fault. In 17 A.D. a large earthquake hit this area and it was so devastating that it completely destroyed the city of Sardis and ten other cities. Philadelphia was not totally destroyed, but for years the city had constant tremors which caused walls to continue to tumble in on people. The citizens had to live in terror of what the next moment might bring. In fact, the majority of the population left the city because of the unending tremors. Because of the earthquakes and tremors, the people were able to relate to two things the Lord spoke of in **Revelation 3:12** (NKJV) ***“He who overcomes, I will make him a pillar in the temple of My God, and he shall go out no more. And I will write on him the name of My God and the name of the city of My God, the New Jerusalem, which comes down out of heaven from My God. And I will write on him My new name.”*** (1) Because of the constant threat of buildings falling in, the people would build pillars in their homes to support their homes during earthquakes. Generally, the people with large pillars in their homes were safe during the tremors. God was saying that over-comers would be strong and could stand the spiritual tremors Satan would send, and because of that, they would be safe because they were ***“...pillars in the temple of my God...”*** Because of this, the Christians could relate to the term ***“pillar”*** which is being used here. (2) To those who would be over-comers, He said in verse 12, ***“....he shall go no more out...”*** They could certainly relate to this as they had to run in and out of their houses as the unending tremors terrorized their lives. They were being told that one day they would not have to live under such conditions. Sometimes, the best way for Christians to fight discouragement is to recognize that one day we are not going to have to face the battles we now face. The song writer said, ***“It will be worth it all when we see Jesus.”***
- **The new name given to this city...** After one large earthquake Philadelphia was totally destroyed. The emperor, Tiberius aided this city tremendously in their rebuilding effort. Out of gratitude, the name of the city was changed to Neocaesarea, the new city of Caesar. In **verse 12** we see they could relate to these words, ***“...I will write upon him the name of my God, and the name of the city of my God, which is new Jerusalem, which cometh down out of heaven from my God: and I will write upon him my new name.”*** After seeing Philadelphia rebuilt and given a new name, they could relate to the

new name “....*of the city of my God....*” that they (and all who have accepted Christ) would inherit through the Christ which has made it possible.

- [The city's Synagogue...](#) The Jews claimed to be the true followers of God and they claimed they had the keys of David which was given to them and they had the right to open and shut the door to God and His kingdom. [Revelation 3:7](#) (NKJV) *“And to the angel of the church in Philadelphia write, ‘These things says He who is holy, He who is true, “He who has the key of David, He who opens and no one shuts, and shuts and no one opens.”*

I. THE KEEPER OF THE KEYS...

Notice the description of the Lord Jesus Christ. [Revelation 3:7](#) (NKJV) *“And to the angel of the church in Philadelphia write, ‘These things says He who is holy, He who is true, “He who has the key of David, He who opens and no one shuts, and shuts and no one opens.”*

If I asked you to describe the late John Wayne, you would probably say he was a tall, handsome fellow with brown hair, blue eyes, a deep voice and that he spoke with authority.

If anyone described Christ as being five foot eleven inches tall, having dark hair and blue eyes, they would be describing Him like an ordinary man.

[Christ was an ordinary man, but He was also much more!](#)

We use various adjectives to describe one another but we know that a description of the Lord Jesus Christ requires a much greater level of descriptive terminology.

[Jesus is revealed as the keeper of the keys.](#) He has the keys to the past present and future of every person who has ever been born. [Hebrews 13:8](#) (NKJV) *“Jesus Christ is the same yesterday, today, and forever.”*

Throughout life, we are constantly being confronted with doors which are opened and doors which are shut, doors which are locked and doors which are unlocked. For the Christian, the door which is shut or locked is no reason for alarm because Christ is the keeper of the keys.

All of us know we could not have accomplished the things we have, if God not opened doors for us! (Turtle on a stump...) Some folks may never admit

it, but none of us would experience any success without the help of the Lord!
Acts 17:28 (NKJV) ***“For in Him we live and move and have our being...”***

The good news in our text is that Jesus is the keeper of the keys. Even though we do not relish the idea of having a door slammed in our faces, we can all be thankful that the Lord we serve, knows what doors should be opened and what doors should be closed.

Jesus has the key to every circumstance in our lives and we do not have to know key people when we know the keeper of the keys. I believe in Divine appointments or Kingdom Connections, but we must realize those things and times have been predetermined by the one who holds the keys to our future. (On 6/07/06 God placed a person in my life in a restaurant on my way home from church to provide an outreach vehicle for CT! I NEVER go to that restaurant!)

Notice two things about the keeper of the keys:

- He is a righteous... Revelation 3:7 (NKJV) ***“And to the angel of the church in Philadelphia write, ‘These things says He who is holy, He who is true, “He who has the key of David, He who opens and no one shuts, and shuts and no one opens”*** As we walk down the path of life we can rest assured that when the Lord opens and shuts doors before us, He will never open an unhealthy door before us, nor will he shut a beneficial door before we can enter it. He is fair and even-handed. God wants His people to know He is the keeper of the keys, and the doors He opens will be doors which will be beneficial to the Kingdom as well as in the best interest of the individual.
- He is resourceful... Revelation 3:7 (NKJV) ***“And to the angel of the church in Philadelphia write, ‘These things says He who is holy, He who is true, “He who has the key of David, He who opens and no one shuts, and shuts and no one opens”*** Isaiah 22:22-24 (NKJV) ***“The key of the house of David I will lay on his shoulder; So he shall open, and no one shall shut; And he shall shut, and no one shall open. 23 I will fasten him as a peg in a secure place, And he will become a glorious throne to his father’s house. 24 ‘They will hang on him all the glory of his father’s house, the offspring and the posterity, all vessels of small quantity, from the cups to all the pitchers.”*** When a person suddenly comes into possession of a windfall of resources they are usually very surprised at how many new friends they have. This is human nature; we want to be

connected to people with resources because it makes us feel that our future is more secure. We must always realize that people and possessions are not the source for the Christian, the keeper of the keys is our source! Philippians 4:19 (NKJV) ***“And my God shall supply all your need according to His riches in glory by Christ Jesus.”***

God wanted the church of Philadelphia to know that He was the keeper of the keys and He alone would provide their needs even though they were living in fearful and stressful conditions.

II. THE KEEPER OF KNOWLEDGE...

Revelation 3:8-10 (NKJV) ***“I know your works. See, I have set before you an open door, and no one can shut it; for you have a little strength, have kept My word, and have not denied My name.9 “Indeed I will make those of the synagogue of Satan, who say they are Jews and are not, but lie—indeed I will make them come and worship before your feet, and to know that I have loved you.10 “Because you have kept My command to persevere, I also will keep you from the hour of trial which shall come upon the whole world, to test those who dwell on the earth.”***

There is no question that God will one day judge sin and each person which has not covered their sin with the blood of Jesus will perish. It is important that we remember this, because each deed we do will be judged by a God who is the keeper of all knowledge.

On judgment day the world will be made painfully aware that it is impossible for anyone to sin and God not know about it. When I was growing up in church they used to sing a song which said *“There’s an all seeing eye watching you.”*

God is not only a keeper of bad knowledge, but He is the keeper of good works as well. God commends the church of Philadelphia for four things...

- Their works... Revelation 3:8 (NKJV) ***“I know your works...”*** We are not saved by works, we are saved by grace through faith but we will surely be rewarded for works! Ephesians 2:10 (NKJV) ***“For we are His workmanship, created in Christ Jesus for good works, which God prepared beforehand that we should walk in them.”*** Someone said, *“Faith alone saves, but faith that saves is not alone.”* Something is certainly awry when a person professes to have faith but does not have any works. The church of Philadelphia was a working church.

- Their strength... Revelation 3:8 (NKJV) “...you have a little strength...” The word translated “*strength*,” is from the Greek word, “*Dunamis*” from which we get our word dynamite. God said that they had a little power. It is believed that the church of Philadelphia was not large in numbers, nor did they have an impressive building, or all kinds of programs. It is believed that they were a little group of humble folks who loved the Lord and served Him effectively. Though small in numbers, they were walking through the doors God opened for them. God saw this church, as a small, humble, powerful church. God said the church of Philadelphia had a little strength and obviously that was all that was needed.
- Their loyalty... Revelation 3:8 (NKJV) “... You have kept My word...” Not only was the Word of God preached in this church, it was followed implicitly. For a church to be what God would have it be, it must have two things: (1) A minister who will boldly declare the Word of God... (2) A congregation who will hear the Word of God and follow its precepts. When either of these ingredients is missing in a church, the church is in trouble.
- Their fidelity... Revelation 3:8 (NKJV) “... You have not denied My name...” The church of Philadelphia was not serving the Lord because it was the popular thing to do. Many of them were being persecuted and even martyred but they knew the path they had chosen would eventually pay off in a large way. This street turns to gold! Revelation 3:9-10 (NKJV) “Indeed I will make those of the synagogue of Satan, who say they are Jews and are not, but lie—indeed I will make them come and worship before your feet, and to know that I have loved you.10 “Because you have kept My command to persevere, I also will keep you from the hour of trial which shall come upon the whole world, to test those who dwell on the earth.” Fidelity will always be rewarded.

CONCLUSION: We are to look forward to the day when we will receive the reward at the end of the race. Listen to what Paul say’s to Timothy in 2 Timothy 4:1-8 (NKJV) “*I charge you therefore before God and the Lord Jesus Christ, who will judge the living and the dead at His appearing and His kingdom:2 Preach the word! Be ready in season and out of season. Convince, rebuke, exhort, with all longsuffering and teaching.3 For the time will come when they will not endure sound doctrine, but according to*

their own desires, because they have itching ears, they will heap up for themselves teachers;⁴ and they will turn their ears away from the truth, and be turned aside to fables.⁵ But you be watchful in all things, endure afflictions, do the work of an evangelist, fulfill your ministry. ⁶ For I am already being poured out as a drink offering, and the time of my departure is at hand.⁷ I have fought the good fight, I have finished the race, I have kept the faith.⁸ Finally, there is laid up for me the crown of righteousness, which the Lord, the righteous Judge, will give to me on that Day, and not to me only but also to all who have loved His appearing."

SEVEN CHURCHES THE CHURCH OF LAODICEA

TEXT: Revelation 3:14-22 (NKJV) *“And to the angel of the church of the Laodiceans write, ‘These things says the Amen, the Faithful and True Witness, the Beginning of the creation of God:15 “I know your works, that you are neither cold nor hot. I could wish you were cold or hot.16 “So then, because you are lukewarm, and neither cold nor hot, I will vomit you out of My mouth.17 “Because you say, ‘I am rich, have become wealthy, and have need of nothing’—and do not know that you are wretched, miserable, poor, blind, and naked—18 “I counsel you to buy from Me gold refined in the fire, that you may be rich; and white garments, that you may be clothed, that the shame of your nakedness may not be revealed; and anoint your eyes with eye salve, that you may see.19 “As many as I love, I rebuke and chasten. Therefore be zealous and repent.20 “Behold, I stand at the door and knock. If anyone hears My voice and opens the door, I will come in to him and dine with him, and he with Me.21 “To him who overcomes I will grant to sit with Me on My throne, as I also overcame and sat down with My Father on His throne.22 “He who has an ear, let him hear what the Spirit says to the churches.”*

INTRO: Many of us have taken a bite of something and the moment it was in the mouth we had to *“spew”* (spit) it out (My experiencing drinking a solution in preparation for a medical test...). With this in mind I would like to draw your attention to the church of Laodicea. Jesus spoke of this church as being a church that caused Him to *“spew”* them out because they were *“lukewarm.”*

There are very few people around who like lukewarm coffee. Some like it iced, and most like it hot, but very few go into a restaurant and order a cup of lukewarm coffee. Why? To most, lukewarm coffee is nauseating.

The church of Laodicea was lukewarm, spiritually, and their lukewarm condition nauseated the Lord.

There are several historical facts that we need to consider about the city of Laodicea which will help us better understand the reprimand from the Lord to this church. Consider the following things concerning the city of Laodicea:

- It was a well known financial banking center...

- It was a well known clothing manufacturing center...
- It was a well known medical center...
- It was especially well known for the eye salve which was produced there...

We see each of these things referred to in the letter to this church. Verse 17, ***“...You are wretched, miserable, poor, blind, and naked...”***

The Lord found something good to say about each of the other six churches we have studied, but notice that when He came to the church of Laodicea, He could not find one good thing to say about them. This church made Him sick!

The Lord points out the ***“lukewarm”*** condition of the church of Laodicea and in doing so allows us to see His extreme displeasure with its condition...

I. THE CAUSE OF LUKEWARMNESS...

This church had no one to blame except them-selves. Notice, in verse 14, who the Lord was addressing; ***“And unto the angel of the church of the Laodiceans’ write...”*** Remember, the ***“angel”*** that was being addressed was the pastor of the church. The pastor is God’s messenger. God holds the pastor responsible for maintaining a warm relationship with Himself and leading the church into a personal relationship with Him as well. We have talked about the Pastor being the person in authority and setting the direction for the church, but we must also understand that when things go wrong the Pastor is the first person to accept responsibility!

It is believed that Archippus was the pastor of the church of Laodicea. Paul wrote him in Colossians 4:17 ***“...Take heed to the ministry which thou hast received in the Lord, that thou fulfill it.”*** The terrible sin of being lukewarm probably began with the Pastor. In Paul’s writing he seemed to indicate that Archippus was not taking the work of God seriously. Paul told him to ***“...Take heed...”*** or to pay attention!

God will hold pastors responsible for keeping their relationship with the Lord on the front burner, not allowing the fire of passion to go out! Keeping the lamp clean and burning was one of the paramount responsibilities of the Old Testament Priest.

God addresses the Pastor and then expects him to address the congregation.

In sharing His complaint against this church, Jesus leaves no allowance for misunderstanding as to who the complaint was from. [Look at how He identifies the complainant:](#)

- [The complainant is the truth...](#) Look at [verse 14](#), “...*These things saith the Amen....*” Jesus referred to Himself as “*the Amen.*” Why? Because amen is a term that declares and guarantees the truth. For example, when a preacher is preaching God’s Word, people will often say Amen. This is a comment that indicates that what they are hearing is the truth and that the truth is agreeing with their spirit. The Lord, Who had only bad things to say to this church, wanted them to know what He was saying and what they were hearing was the truth. So, Christ referred to Himself as “*the Amen.*”
- [The complainant is a witness...](#) Look at [verse 14](#), “...*These things saith the faithful and true witness...*” Remember, the church of Laodicea is a lukewarm church. They would passionately serve God one day and not serve Him the next. They would spread the truth one day and a lie the next. But Christ wanted them to know He was the opposite of what they were and that He was a faithful witness. He did not speak the truth one day and a lie the next. He was the Faithful and True Witness that told the truth every day. As a faithful and true witness He was letting them know that He would testify against their actions as an unimpeachable witness!
- [The Complainant is the beginning...](#) Again, [verse 14](#), “...*These things saith the beginning of the creation of God.*” What we believe about the origin of man basically comes down to two things. Either we place our faith in speculation, or we place our faith in revelation. God wanted them to know there was no guessing about what He was going to say when He testified against them. He said, “...*These things saith the beginning of the creation of God.*” The complainant wanted them to know that He was from the beginning, and He would be a witness against them from the beginning unto the end!

[II. The Complaint...](#)

Rev. 3:15-16 (KJV) “*I know thy works, that thou art neither cold nor hot; I would thou wert cold or hot. So then because thou art lukewarm, and neither cold nor hot, I will spew thee out of my mouth.*”

God knows the spiritual condition of every church. Notice what He bases the spiritual condition of this church on. ***"I know thy works...."*** Their works revealed to Him that they were neither cold nor hot.

Have you noticed that people who are on fire for God cannot do enough for Him, and those who are lukewarm must be forced into every task? Why?

The person who is "lukewarm" is:

- Indifferent...
- Self-absorbed...
- Complacent...

Those who find themselves in this place are:

- Not committed to worship... They stay out of church about as much as they come, and when they do come, they sleep through the service or cannot wait for it to end.
- Not committed to evangelism... They are not filled with enough interest in the Lord to compel them to spread the Gospel.
- Not committed to teaching and preaching God's Word... The sermon is too long and too loud... They fail to commit to discipleship...
- Not committed to living a dedicated Christian life... They become situational Christians...
- Not committed to supporting the church financially... They fail to pay their tithes and get upset when the preacher mentions it.

A lukewarm church is a church which has been deceived into thinking everything is alright when it is not. There are many deceived churches in this society. Look what the Lord says about the church of Laodicea.

Revelation 3:17 (KJV) ***"Because thou sayest, I am rich, and increased with goods, and have need of nothing; and knowest not that thou art wretched, and miserable, and poor, and blind, and naked."*** If you or I had been able to attend the Laodicean church, the first things we would have noticed were:

- How big their building was...
- How well kept the grounds were...
- How big their staff was...
- How many programs they offered...
- How much their budget was...

The membership would tell us what a good church they had. At the same time, if Christ had walked up while you were there, He would have said that that church was a “*wretched*” church!

The cause for the complaint was due to a false self-assessment.

III. THE CURE FOR THEIR CONDITION...

The church of Laodicea thought they were doing pretty well with their riches, fine clothing, and medical advancements but the problem remained, a faulty self-assessment. This church did not feel that they were in need of anything, yet, the Lord told them how they looked in His sight, which revealed the sad fact that they were in a deplorable condition!

He counseled them to buy:

- [Spiritual gold...](#) Vs. 18 - *“I counsel you to buy from Me gold refined in the fire, that you may be rich...”* Unless a person has spiritual wealth, he really does not have any wealth at all. [Matthew 16:26](#) (NKJV) *“For what profit is it to a man if he gains the whole world, and loses his own soul? Or what will a man give in exchange for his soul?”*
- [Spiritual clothing...](#) We could have the most expensive name brand clothes, yet be naked and undone in the eyes of the Lord because the clothes of the Saints is the righteousness of Christ. Vs. 18 - *“I counsel you to buy from Me... white garment that you may be clothed, that the shame of your nakedness may not be revealed...”* [2 Corinthians 5:1-4](#) *“For we know that if our earthly house, this tent, is destroyed, we have a building from God, a house not made with hands, eternal in the heavens.² For in this we groan, earnestly desiring to be clothed with our habitation which is from heaven,³ if indeed, having been clothed, we shall not be found naked.⁴ For we who are in this tent groan, being burdened, not because we want to be unclothed, but further clothed, that mortality may be swallowed up by life.”*
- [Spiritual medicine...](#) We have available to us the best medical care the world has ever known. Yet, unless we are walking around forgiven by the blood of Jesus, we have the worst condition known to man. Vs. 18 - *“I counsel you to... anoint your eyes with eye salve, that you may see.* We can have 20/20 vision, yet if we cannot see

through the eyes of Jesus, we can see nothing at all. We are not to lean upon the arm of flesh but upon the great Physician.

Regardless of their condition, the Lord wanted them to know He loved them. Look at [Revelation 3:19](#), ***“As many as I love, I rebuke and chasten....”*** He wanted them to know the reason He was chastening them was because He loved them and His advice for them was to repent! This is a picture of a caring parent correcting and disciplining a child. [The discipline is not for the parent’s pleasure but for the child’s good.](#) Look at verse 19-21 ***“As many as I love, I rebuke and chasten; be zealous therefore, and repent. Behold, I stand at the door and knock; if any man hear my voice, and open the door, I will come in to him, and will sup with him, and he with me. To him that overcometh will I grant to sit with me in my throne, even as I also overcame, and am set down with my Father in his throne.”***

CONCLUSION: The Lord Jesus did not have one compliment for this church. Why? They were not complimented because they were found to be in a ***“lukewarm”*** condition.

The Lord Jesus would have some very harsh things to say of the present condition of the church today because ***“lukewarm”*** describes the condition of the modern day church. [A “lukewarm” condition is characterized by:](#)

- Works without [passion](#)...
- Prayer without [fasting](#)...
- Giving without [sacrificing](#)...
- Witnessing without [weeping](#)...

It should be no surprise to us if we sow without reaping!

It is time that lukewarm Christians stop straddling the fence and decide whose side they are on! Become hot rather than cold!